



Emerging force: There is little subtle about Tessa Jolly's game from the back of the court. The power is obvious. What stood out in Delhi was everything she added around it.

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worrying about what is happening behind her.

In Delhi, there was something more. Tessa proved she was more than capable of coming forward to the net, while Gayatri showed she could produce sharp smashes from the back of the court, albeit not of the Tessa jump-shot variety.

That evolution was critical to their success. When the two are functioning together, they can switch from defence to attack in a matter of seconds. Against Jia and Zhang, they showed that they could absorb pressure and come back. Against Liu and Tan, they showed that they could impose it, at least for a game. Tessa

and Gayatri know they have something special in their hands.

There is another reason the medal feels significant. Gayatri has spent much of her career having to live with the unavoidable presence of her father Pullela Gopichand's name. It has been impossible for her to enter a badminton court without carrying the enormous reputation of the former All England champion and Indian badminton coach with her.

It's unlikely this pressure goes away completely. But now Gayatri is no longer simply the daughter of one of Indian badminton's greatest players and coaches. She is a World Championships medallist in her own right.

Tessa, meanwhile, has emerged from a system that has produced relatively few elite women's doubles players. For years, India's women's doubles success has largely been associated with Jwala and Ashwini, followed by brief periods in which

Own legacy: She grew up in the shadow of a badminton great. Now Gayatri Gopinath is stepping into her own light. GETTY IMAGES

different combinations threatened to break through.

The medal in New Delhi suggests that Gayatri and Tessa may finally have the ingredients to sustain India's presence at the top rather than merely produce isolated victories.

There's enough to suggest that the performance in Delhi isn't a fluke. There will likely be more semifinals. There will be more packed stadiums. There will be more moments when the score is tight, and the crowd starts looking for something to shout. And there may well be more occasions when someone starts the chant again.

"Pullela, Pullela!"

"Jolly good, Jolly good!"